



*Executive Memoir
May 14, 1861
Hon. Sec. of War
My dear Sir
The bearer of this letter
now before you, is my particular friend,
residing in Illinois. He wishes to
supply horses for the army - being
perhaps one of the best breeders
he could get at, a few times for
the Govt & himself. I have
affiliated him for him out of
your friendly care.
Yours truly,
Abraham Lincoln.*

Man of letters

Lincoln wrote this letter to his Secretary of War, Simon Cameron, in May 1861, recommending that his friend, Alexander Sympton, be given a contract to supply the army with horses. In other letters, Lincoln constantly urged his generals to prosecute the war with greater energy and resolution.

A Presidential visit

Lincoln visits the Union army camp at Antietam in October 1862. He is flanked by intelligence chief Allan Pinkerton (left) and General John A. McClernand, one of the Union army's many lamentably unsuccessful military commanders.

military experience, he showed a better grasp of the principles of warfare than most of his generals. It was not until 1864 that he found in Ulysses S. Grant a commander-in-chief whose implacable will matched his own.

Lincoln's legacy

Even in the thick of the war, Lincoln found a chance to advance the material progress in which he so firmly believed. He oversaw the creation of a National Bank, laid the foundations for the building of the Pacific Railroad, and prepared the way for the carving up of the prairies into small farms with the Homestead Act. On slavery, it was only after his reelection in 1864 that he was able to press for a constitutional amendment to abolish the practice and to advocate full citizenship and voting rights for black Americans.

Lincoln's unequaled rhetoric, both in his Gettysburg Address of 1863 and his second inaugural speech of 1865, gave the war a dignity it would otherwise have lacked. His assassination by fanatic John Wilkes Booth at the moment of victory for the Union army was a national tragedy.

THE GUN THAT SHOT LINCOLN



Assassination at Ford's Theatre

Watching the play *Our American Cousin*, alongside his wife Mary, Lincoln was shot in the head by John Wilkes Booth. He was carried to a boarding house opposite the theater, where he died early the following morning.



"Let us strive on to finish the work we are in; to bind up the nation's wounds."

ABRAHAM LINCOLN, INAUGURAL ADDRESS, MARCH 4, 1865

man could make something of himself. Slavery denied an individual the chance of self-betterment.

The reluctant abolitionist

Although he denounced slavery as morally wrong, Lincoln did not adopt an abolitionist stance, accepting that slavery would persist in the southern states. Even so, his antislavery position during public debates with Illinois Democrat Stephen A. Douglas in 1858 made him a figure of hate for Southerners. His statement that the United States government "could not endure permanently half-slave and half-free" was seen as an invitation to civil war.

As an inelegant, awkward westerner with limited political experience, Lincoln was not the obvious choice for Republican presidential candidate in 1860, but he slipped through as a compromise between conflicting factions. With the Democrats divided, he won the presidency with less than 40 percent of the popular vote. Diehard Southerners had made it clear his election would provoke secession (withdrawal) from the Union. So bitter was the atmosphere that Lincoln had to sneak into Washington in disguise to take up his office because of the threat of assassination.

Lincoln at first fatally underestimated the strength of secessionist sentiment and the force that would be required to overcome it. However, with the outbreak of civil war in 1861 between the northern states (the Union) and southern states (the Confederacy), Lincoln showed an unflinching will for victory. His position as president was precarious. He was despised by the political elite, opposed by factions on both wings of his own party, and threatened by discontented generals. He had to maneuver and compromise to maintain the support for the war. Yet with almost no

TIMELINE

- **February 12, 1809** Abraham Lincoln is born in a log cabin near Hodgenville, Kentucky.
- **December 9, 1818** Lincoln's mother, Nancy Hanks Lincoln, dies at age 34; the following year his father, Thomas Lincoln, marries Sarah Bush Johnston.
- **1832** Serves as a captain of militia in the Black Hawk War against Sauk and Fox Indians.
- **1834** Standing as a Whig Party candidate, Lincoln is elected for the first of four consecutive terms in the Illinois House of Representatives.
- **1837** Qualifies as a lawyer and begins his legal career in the Illinois state capital, Springfield.
- **November 4, 1842** Marries Mary Todd, member of a slave-owning Kentucky family.
- **1846–49** Serves a term as a Whig in the US House of Representatives. His unpopular opposition to the United States' war with Mexico halts his political career.
- **February 1, 1850** Lincoln's second son, Edward Baker Lincoln, dies at age 3.
- **1854** Reenters politics, helping found the Republican Party to oppose the spread of slavery.
- **1858** Stands as Republican candidate for the Senate; he loses to Stephen A. Douglas, but his debates with Douglas on the slavery issue seal his reputation.
- **May 16, 1860** Wins the Republican nomination for the presidency of the United States as a compromise candidate.
- **November 6, 1860** Lincoln is elected 16th President of the United States with 39.9 percent of the popular vote; seven Southern states respond by seceding from the Union.
- **March 4, 1861** In his inaugural address, Lincoln promises to uphold the Union, but also to protect slavery in states where it already exists.
- **April 1861** After Confederates fire on Union troops at Fort Sumter, Lincoln calls for military action to "preserve the Union"; four more states join the Confederacy and the Civil War begins.
- **February 20, 1862** Lincoln's third son, William, dies at age 11.
- **September 22, 1862** Lincoln announces the Emancipation Proclamation, declaring slaves in Confederate states free; it comes into force on January 1, 1863.
- **November 8, 1864** Supported by a coalition of Republicans and War Democrats, Lincoln is reelected president with 55 percent of the popular vote.
- **February 1, 1865** Signs a resolution proposing the 13th Amendment, abolishing slavery in the United States.
- **April 14, 1865** Lincoln is shot by John Wilkes Booth at Ford's Theatre, Washington, D.C. He dies the following day.



MARY LINCOLN